

Chapter 136 - Inquiry

The cold stone hall was instantly filled with many objects, especially the table covered with flowers, while the ancient oil lamps surrounding the stone hall had been replaced with red candles, crackling as they burned and casting romantic red glows.

Ning Fuyi was stretching her finger to pick through things on the table, lowering her head to pull out a flower.

"I think our home should be more lively. What do you think?" Ning Fuyi smiled brilliantly, holding the flower.

"Home?" Chu Qingqiu put down her white bone staff, looking rather unaccustomed as she surveyed those colorful flowers. "It's just a stone house anyway. How can it be made lively?"

"Even iron trees can bloom¹. Why can't a stone hall?" Ning Fuyi stepped forward to snatch the jade flute from Chu Qingqiu's hand, grinning as she pulled her toward the sleeping chamber.

Chu Qingqiu didn't refuse, following her all the way into the sleeping chamber. It had indeed changed - the originally cold stone bed was covered with white petals, with curtains hanging from above to conceal the stone bed. Though the changes weren't major, it was warmer by several degrees.

"How is it?" Ning Fuyi spread her hands.

Chu Qingqiu looked left and right, nodding: "Acceptable to the eye."

Then she changed the subject, reaching out to grab Ning Fuyi's collar: "Don't try to change the topic. Were those crude words on the wall written by your hand?"

Ning Fuyi smiled as she grasped her fingers, slowly pressing them down: "Young and ignorant of worldly affairs. Divine Venerable, you're at least ten thousand years older than me. How can you argue with a child?"

Chu Qingqiu snorted and turned to leave.

Ning Fuyi turned back to adjust the curtain positions again before cheerfully chasing after her, looking around as she asked: "This vast Purple Cloud Peak has only you and Qiuyi. Don't you feel lonely at all during ordinary days?"

"There's not even enough time for cultivation. Where would loneliness come from?" Chu Qingqiu said indifferently. She found a stone chair to sit in, waved her hand to light a lamp, and pulled out several sheets of paper.

Ning Fuyi stood beside her watching: "What are you doing?"

Chu Qingqiu's peach blossom eyes glanced at her, her hands never stopping: "The Divine-Demon Manual. Did you forget?"

"I haven't forgotten," Ning Fuyi crouched down beside her, placing her hands on the table with her chin resting on the back of her hand, looking up pitifully. "But we finally have the whole mountain to ourselves, yet you only care about the Divine-Demon Manual and won't spend time with me?"

"I'm right here. How else should I accompany you?" Chu Qingqiu raised her hand to draw two marks on her nose, then pressed her forehead with her index finger. "Besides, this thing is useful to you. I want to finish copying it soon."

With that, she lowered her head to copy earnestly.

Ning Fuyi let out a long sigh. This was just Chu Qingqiu's temperament - she would never delay important matters. Unable to disturb her, Ning Fuyi could only find a place to sit down and, like that night, lie prone watching her profile.

Outside, the sky grew increasingly dark. Several sparse stars were already showing their light, the azure sky clean as a wash, with wispy clouds bearing ink-like traces.

Watching her write made Ning Fuyi's heart itch. Finally, she could only get up, making the excuse of getting fresh air as she walked out of the stone hall into the crisp night wind outside.

White Lin was curled up sleeping on the steps. Ning Fuyi went forward to wake it, using both hands to pry open its sleepy eyes, saying rudely: "Your master won't pay attention to me, so you have to play with me."

White Lin snorted, rolling its eyes to show its snow-white belly like a huge cat.

"Come on." Ning Fuyi tugged its tail.

So half an incense stick's time later, one person and one tiger wandered along Purple Cloud Peak's rubble-strewn path toward the depths.

There was no place quieter than Purple Cloud Peak - not even a bird's cry could be heard. The mountain had no flowers, grass, or trees either, and with no wind tonight, Ning Fuyi could only hear her own and White Lin's footsteps.

"I actually feel sorry for you, living on this mountain with her for so long. It must be terribly boring, right?" Ning Fuyi asked.

White Lin shook its head and nodded, its thick tail raised high.

Ning Fuyi walked far out. The sky grew deeper blue, the moon half-obscured by thin clouds, rather like "still holding a pipa, half-covering her face²." Ning Fuyi turned a corner and saw a stretch of smooth green stones before her.

Those stone blocks were large and small but densely arranged. Stepping across the green stone beach, a pool of water appeared in the center - clear water that reflected like a mirror.

"How can there be a clear pool on this Purple Cloud Peak where not a blade of grass grows?" Ning Fuyi half-crouched down, putting her hand in to test the water.

The pool water was actually warm, though not scalding. The water ripples she stirred broke apart a pool full of moonlight.

Ning Fuyi's sharp eyes spotted a fire-red stone in the center, and she immediately understood. That stone was called Red Flame Stone³, generally only found in the middle of Fire Mountains. It could maintain heat year-round and was commonly used to warm bathing pools.

Since the scenery here was nice - though the mountain had no greenery, looking out you could see verdant mountain ranges, the evening peaks like paintings outlined against the night sky, beautiful and magnificent.

Ning Fuyi removed her clothing and slipped into the pool, opening her eyes to gaze at the moonlight. Before long, she began to doze.

Meanwhile, Chu Qingqiu put down her brush and paper, let out a long breath, folded the papers into a booklet, sealed it with immortal power, stood up and walked out of the hall door. Looking around, she didn't see Ning Fuyi's figure.

Could it be that because she didn't accompany her, she was throwing a tantrum? Chu Qingqiu felt somewhat guilty. She stepped on her white bone staff to rise into the air, wanting to find her.

The figure wasn't hard to find - she could see White Lin's exposed snow-white belly from far away. She released her power to descend, and after her robes settled, she walked forward gracefully.

Black hair floated in the pool water, with Ning Fuyi's half-face submerged underwater. At first glance, Chu Qingqiu was immediately terrified, her white silk unconsciously emerging from her sleeve to lift the person from the water.

However, her terror didn't diminish at all. When that body still covered with water drops fell into view, she immediately released the white silk. With a splash, water flew everywhere.

The splashing water scared even the sleeping White Lin, who rolled over with alert growls. Seeing the newcomer was Chu Qingqiu, the growls quickly turned to whimpers.

"White Lin, go back," Chu Qingqiu's pale face flushed red as fruit, hurriedly waving her sleeve to chase White Lin away from the area.

Ning Fuyi had originally been dozing peacefully when she was suddenly lifted and thrown back, swallowing a nose full of water. After flailing twice, she finally emerged, looking through the water mist at Chu Qingqiu whose gaze was wandering wildly.

"What are you doing?" She found it quite inexplicable, then suddenly remembered something, her eyes widening as she blushed and pulled clothes from between the rocks, hastily draping them over herself.

"Sorry," Chu Qingqiu was rarely not calm, turning her body halfway toward the mountain ranges. "I saw you sunk at the bottom of the water and was momentarily anxious..."

As she spoke, the glimpse from earlier kept drilling into her mind. Chu Qingqiu forgot what she was going to say next and awkwardly cut off mid-sentence.

Usually that body was hidden by black robes, always seeming slender. Only now, accidentally seeing it openly, did she realize it wasn't so - the waist and limbs were all just right, healthy and beautiful.

The ability of photographic memory was useful during cultivation, but now it became a hindrance. The more Chu Qingqiu tried to forget, the clearer that image became, until she felt heat rising from her thoughts.

Ning Fuyi stood half in the water, suspiciously staring at her complexion, then suddenly curved her phoenix eyes in a smile, spinning to shore and reaching out to touch her shoulder.

"Divine Venerable surely doesn't think I could drown in this little pool, right?"

"Your demonic energy is unstable. Who could know if you might or might not?" Chu Qingqiu pretended to be unaffected.

Ning Fuyi brushed off her own shoulder, and the water on her body disappeared. She lowered her head to take Chu Qingqiu's hand - the cold fingertips trembled for an instant as they were grasped in her palm, without rejection.

"The scenery here is beautiful, like a landscape painting. Is that beyond the mountain ranges Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate?" Ning Fuyi pointed toward the distance.

Chu Qingqiu looked up and hummed in agreement.

"So we've been gazing at each other from afar all along," Ning Fuyi said.

The nearby stones were smooth and warm. Ning Fuyi found a large one to sit on, producing two jugs of peach blossom wine from who knows where. She sniffed them: "I've been drinking this since childhood, the same as what you and I drank in the Primordial Chaos. Won't you try some?"

Chu Qingqiu's face lost its flush as she obediently sat down and accepted a jug.

Ning Fuyi's gaze had never left Chu Qingqiu. Whether it was the pool water or moonlight causing mischief, she always felt today's Chu Qingqiu was different from usual - every inch of color on her body was more vivid: the black of her hair, the red of her vermillion lips, and the faint brown in her pupils.

After she drank a mouthful of wine, crystalline wine stains clung to her lips, and even the transparent stains suddenly became brilliant.

She must be going mad, Ning Fuyi thought silently as she looked up.

"I used to always feel that the grass on the ground and the moon in the sky could only be gazed up at in this lifetime," Ning Fuyi said, shaking her wine jug.

"But later I discovered that if I could grow desperately hard, growing into a towering tree, waiting for the day when the moon hangs on the treetop, then I could meet you."

Today's wine was particularly intoxicating. Chu Qingqiu was also made tipsy by the wine, her eyes flushed underneath. She put down the wine jug, turned her head to look at Ning Fuyi, and in the evening breeze, her eyes actually revealed several points of confusion.

"Yiyi, are we... destined to be an ill-fated relationship⁴?" she asked.

Ning Fuyi also put down her wine jug, trying to look into her eyes: "Whether it's fate or not is still heaven's decision. But to whom I give my heart - that's for me to decide."

The moonlight in Chu Qingqiu's eyes trembled for an instant. Watching Ning Fuyi approach, her unbound long hair bringing fragrance, the scent growing stronger.

Chu Qingqiu curved her lips, the confusion in her eyes gradually driven away by moonlight, turning to clear love.

Why worry about so much? A sentence that definitely wasn't something she would say suddenly flashed through Chu Qingqiu's mind. Then she lowered her brows, watching the woman's nose slowly turn, and then tasted a faint sweetness on her lips.

So she closed her eyes, her hand unconsciously rising to caress that warm palm. When the other party interlocked fingers with her, her heart finally had weight, but still felt empty in one spot, strongly wanting to be filled.

Ning Fuyi's heart also beat like drums, but thanks to the wine's encouragement, her mind had fewer considerations, only focusing on deepening the kiss until their breathing became disordered.

"Yiyi..." Chu Qingqiu said softly. When she looked up, the woman's enchanting face touched by moonlight made her hands weaken several degrees, unable to grip tightly anymore.

Though those elongated phoenix eyes always made her heart flutter, they couldn't compare to this moment's soul-stirring power, like the bottomless night sky above, making stars and moon sink into it.

After one kiss ended, Ning Fuyi suddenly used some force. Their robes became entangled as they fell toward the pool water, but just one inch from the water surface, pink light flashed and the scene beneath them suddenly changed. Chu Qingqiu's back was down, lying among scattered flower petals on the bed.

Several flower petals still floated in mid-air. Their hearts beat like drums, complex fragrances rushing into their embrace. Ning Fuyi slowly propped herself up, pressing her hands down under her palms, asking: "Divine Venerable?"

Chu Qingqiu's eyelashes trembled, finally relaxing her body and softly saying "Good."

Footnotes:

1. **铁树开花 (Iron trees bloom)** - A Chinese idiom meaning something extremely rare or impossible, as iron trees (cycads) very rarely bloom.
2. **犹抱琵琶半遮面** - A famous line from Bai Juyi's poem "Song of the Pipa Player," describing a pipa player who is shy and partially hides her face.
3. **赤炎石 (Red Flame Stone)** - A fictional magical stone that provides heat.
4. **孽缘 (Ill-fated relationship)** - A relationship that is destined to bring suffering or is considered wrong by fate or society.